

The Noble Dhāraṇī Called "Empowerment"

Āryābhiṣiñcanī-nāma-dhāraṇī · Toh 859 · Derge Kangyur

འཕགས་པ་དབང་བསྐྱེད་བ་ཞེས་བ་བྱའི་གཟུངས།

The Noble Dhāraṇī Called "Empowerment" (Sanskrit: Ārya Abhiṣiñcanī Nāma Dhāraṇī; Tibetan: Phags pa dbang bskur ba zhes bya ba'i gzungs) is a short scriptural text that presents itself as a discourse of the Buddha. Like other texts of its kind, it centers on a dhāraṇī, a formula of protective and empowering power that is taught for the benefit of those who receive and practice it. The opening, in the classic style, places the Buddha at Śrāvastī, in Prince Jeta's Grove, with a great assembly of monks and countless bodhisattvas, and shows him addressing Śāriputra on qualities of the bodhisattva path, including the mother of the bodhisattvas, their former conduct, and the aspiration of truth. It is Toh 859 in the Kangyur, the Tibetan canon of the Buddha's word, and belongs to the class of dhāraṇī texts found among the tantra and dhāraṇī sections of that collection.

In the language of India: Ārya Abhiṣiñcanī Nāma Dhāraṇī. In the language of Tibet: The Noble Dhāraṇī Called "Empowerment."

Homage to all the buddhas and bodhisattvas.

Thus did I hear at one time. The Blessed One was dwelling at Śrāvastī, in Prince Jeta's Grove, the park of Anāthapiṇḍada. With him was a great Saṅgha of eight thousand monks, together with countless tens of millions of bodhisattvas who had rendered special service to the victors of the past.

Then the Blessed One spoke to the venerable Śāriputra: "Śāriputra, cultivate and teach these qualities of the bodhisattvas, namely: the mother of the bodhisattvas, the former conduct of the bodhisattvas, the aspiration of truth, and that which the bodhisattvas embrace. That is to say, this Dharma discourse of the dhāraṇī."

Then the venerable Śāriputra said to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, a dhāraṇī does not abide in any place, and it does not abide in any direction. Yet, Blessed One, people say 'dhāraṇī, dhāraṇī.' Blessed One, what is the meaning of this word 'dhāraṇī'?"

When he had said this, the Blessed One spoke to the venerable Śāriputra: "Excellent, Śāriputra, excellent! Śāriputra, you have truly entered the Great Vehicle in this way, you strive earnestly in the Great Vehicle, and you render special service to the Great Vehicle. It is also excellent that you show that a

dhāraṇī does not abide in any place and does not abide in any direction. Why is that? Śāriputra, by its very nature a dhāraṇī is neither past, nor future, nor present. Śāriputra, a dhāraṇī is not explained as past, it is not explained as future, and it is not explained as present. It is not explained as an entity, nor as a non-entity. It is not explained as having signs, nor as signless. It is not explained for the sake of any phenomenon arising or ceasing. Nevertheless, Śāriputra, it is taught out of the wish to benefit bodhisattvas. The dhāraṇī of this Dharma discourse of the dhāraṇī is formless. It has become the path of action. It abides through the power of reasoning. It is the quality of the buddhas. It accomplishes the special service of the buddhas. It is the moral discipline of the buddhas, the compendium of the buddhas, the link to the buddhas, and the arising of the buddhas."

Then the venerable Śāriputra said to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, where does the dhāraṇī abide, such that when a bodhisattva obtains that dhāraṇī, he becomes irreversible from unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, has an excellent commitment, does not abide in phenomena, is himself free of doubt, needs no teacher, and abides on his own path? Blessed One, please explain. Sugata, please explain."

The Blessed One said: "Excellent, Śāriputra, excellent! Śāriputra, a bodhisattva who has obtained the dhāraṇī is called a buddha. Śāriputra, whoever reveres, esteems, serves, or worships a bodhisattva who has obtained the dhāraṇī will thereby have revered all the buddhas. Those who hear this dhāraṇī, and those who have faith in it, will also become worthy of offerings just as the buddhas are, and they will never be separated from the awakening mind.

"Śāriputra, the dhāraṇī is this:

Sandhāraṇī. Uddhāraṇī. Saṃpratiṣṭhita. Sutama. Supratiṣṭhitā. Vijayabalā. Sarvapratiṣṭhā. Ārohaṇāpati. Utpādanī. Vināmanī. Abhiṣiṅgani. Abhivyāhārā. Śubhavati. Anīṣṭa. Bahukumbha. Abhivaca.

"Śāriputra, these are the names of the Dharma of the dhāraṇī called Empowerment: the past ones, the future ones, the present ones, and the well-established ones. Whatever bodhisattva properly takes them up and holds them will, through aspiration, exhaust a hundred eons and a thousand eons, in order to quickly and fully awaken to complete buddhahood. Weapons will not harm him. Fire and savage creatures will not harm him. Why is that? Because, Śāriputra, this dhāraṇī is the mother of the buddhas of the past.

"Śāriputra, suppose some son or daughter of good family were, for countless eons, to provide robes and fine food to as many buddhas as would fill, one after another, ten countless great trichiliocosms. Another son or daughter of good family who holds even a single word of this dhāraṇī will generate far greater merit than that. Why is that? Because, Śāriputra, this dhāraṇī of Empowerment is the mother of the buddhas."

When the Blessed One had spoken thus, those monks, those bodhisattvas, and the world with its gods, humans, asuras, and gandharvas rejoiced and praised what the Blessed One had said.

This completes the Noble Dhāraṇī Called "Empowerment."

It was translated and edited by the Indian preceptors Jinamitra and Dānaśīla and the chief editor and translator, the monk Yeshé Dé. It was then revised in accordance with the new standardized terminology and finalized.

Translator's Notes

- The dhāraṇī words, which derive from Sanskrit, are given in transliteration. The source spells the third one "saṃpratiṣṭita," and it has been normalized to saṃpratiṣṭhita. The phrase rendered "the link to the buddhas" translates mtshams sbyor ba, literally "joining" or "connecting," and its precise sense here is open to interpretation.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.